Tempero Ludum Journal Template

Week 1

Brainstorm Ideas

Mechanics used in game:

- Rolling a dice to determine movement.
- Swap places with opponents.
- Choosing when to use action cards.
- Stealing dice rolls.

Mechanics listed in exercise:

Mechanical ideas:
1) Roll dice for movement
2) Steal dice rolls
3) use rest stop spaces
4) Roll dice to win challenges
5) Roll dice to avoid traps
6) Earn chip points to keep score
7) Solve riddles
8) swap places with an opponent
9) steal chip points
10) trade shop items

Player choices:
1) choose shop items
2) choose what cards to use
3) choose different paths
4) choose when to activate player skills
5) choose when to dice to roll (red and blue dice that do different things)

Week 1 Play test

What went well -

(Due to complications with printing regarding covid, i was unable to print my map out. To work around this, I used a Separate piece of paper and created spaces on it to replicate the spaces used in the game.)

The first test went well. The game can be played fully but because of some of the Pieces effects, it makes the game way longer than it needs to be. There was a lot of stalling that i was able to perform which just made it so no one played the game for 4 turns in a row. This made the game stale and boring which was not my initial design for the game. In total, the competitive and strategic side of the game works well in regards to intent as the goal is for the player to make plays against your opponent to halt their progress but some of the pieces are a bit overpowered and create a not so fun game.

W1T1 What needs to change

Changes that need to be made:

- Either change action piece effects or limit the amount of pieces you can use. This is because with how the game plays now, players are able to repetitively skip the opponent's turn 4 times in a row. This also made it so other cards were not being used as much
- More actions on the board will need to be required as the only action space is to “Select an action” this made the game boring as you could not recycle Pieces you lost.

Was anything confusing to the testers?

The game is straightforward and simple to play, griefing was the biggest issue in the game.

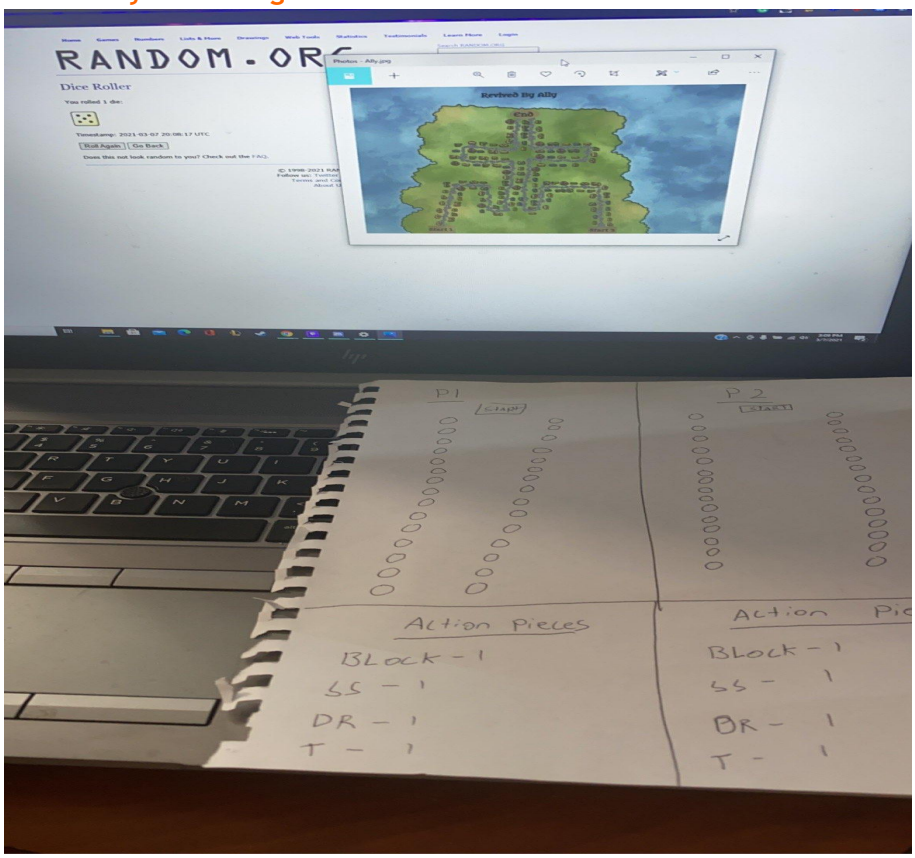
Are any mechanics broken?

Most Notably, the trap piece creates griefing game play and can only be negated with a block card. This mechanic is broken because you have a 50% chance of skipping your opponents next turn.

Did the game last too long or not long enough?

The game did not go over 30 minutes but was much longer than intended because of the skip turn mechanic.

W1T1 Play Test Image



Week 2

Week 2 Play tests

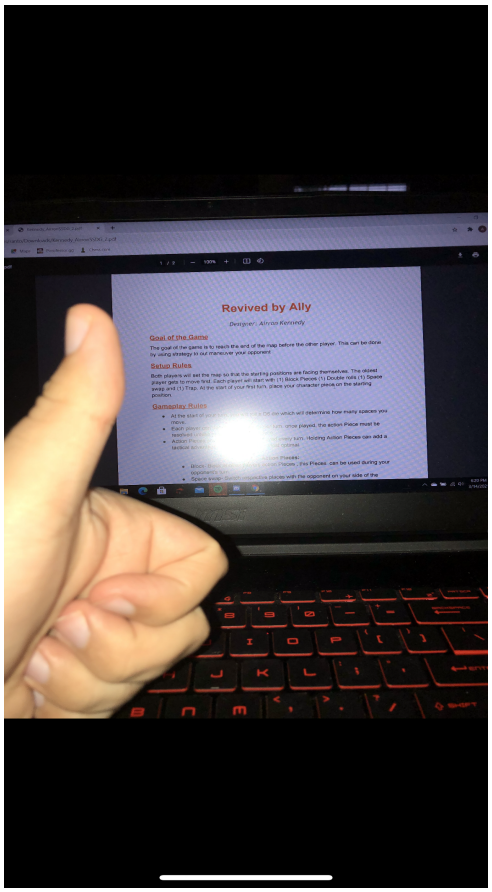
W2 Test #1 What went well -

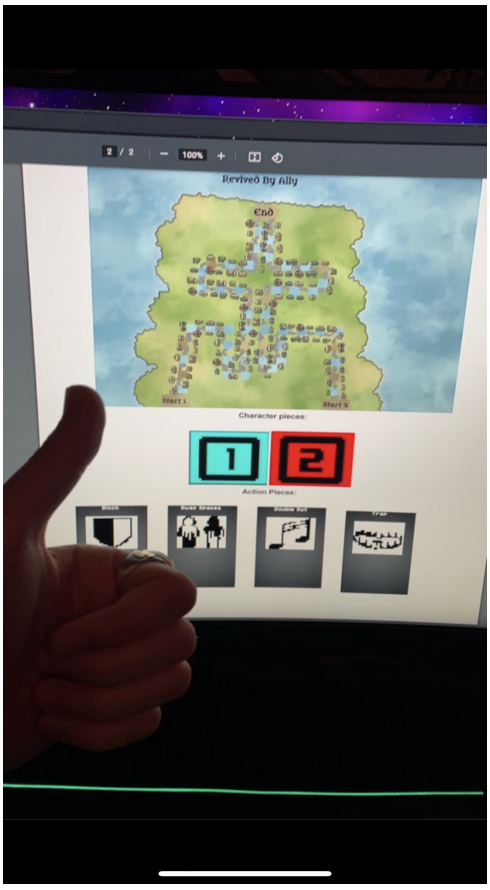
The play tests were conducted off of discord with my friends due to covid restrictions. I helped them make the game board but did not help them with any of the rules or how to play, they just had to figure it out themselves. During this test, players enjoyed blocking the other players' moves for strategy and liked that the game could be played fast. They both understood the rules and were unable to break the game in any way.

W2 Test #1 What needs to change -

During this test, the action pieces were used too often and players could use them repetitively, to negate this, there needs to be restrictions on the action pieces so they cannot be abused. The other issue is that the action piece squares are random and depend on a die roll to get lucky and land on one.

W2T1 Play Test Image





(Both players reading the rules sent via PDF)

W2T1 Play test tracker

1	Revived by ally testing		Player 1	Player 2
2	**1st test:**			
3		1st action piece	Swap spaces	block
4		2nd action piece	Block	double roll
5		3rd action piece	double roll	swap spaces
6		4th action piece	trap	trap
7				
8				
9		Block card used to negate:	double roll	swap spaces
10				
11		Number of turns to win:	18	

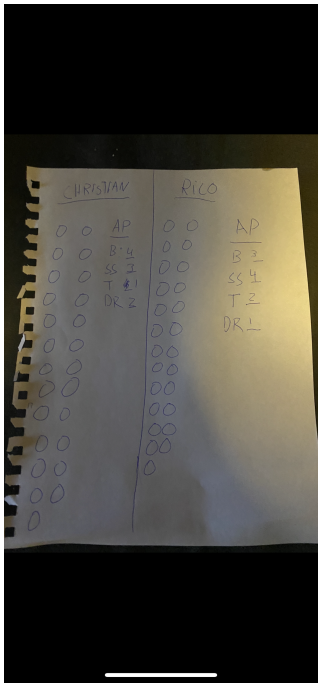
W2 Test #2 What went well -

After changing the amount of times that action pieces were allowed to be used, it made the game more balanced and forced players to really think about when to use them. An example of this was when the player would use the block to negate a swap spaces piece.

W2 Test #2 What needs to change -

Although I thought the changes to the action pieces were good, this made it so both players' action pieces were burned right at the start of the game instead of in the middle of the game. To try to mend this type of play, Action pieces need to be balanced according to how strong they are and when they get used, which can be found in my data.

W2 T2 Play Test Image



(This image shows the game tracker I used to follow along with the players during the game.)

W2 T2 Play test tracker

13	**2nd test:**			
14		1st action piece	trap	double roll
15		2nd action piece	double roll	trap
16		3rd action piece	swap spaces	block
17		4th action piece	block	swap spaces
18				
19				
20		Block card used to negate:	swap spaces	swap paces
21				
22		Number of turns to win:		16
23				

W2 Change List

- Made changes to action pieces as they were too frequent
- Removed piece squares so that players only have 4 Pieces to start with which made it so the pieces were used more strategically.
- Changed the “Swap Spaces” action piece so players could not just zoom to the end.

Week 3

Week 3 Play tests

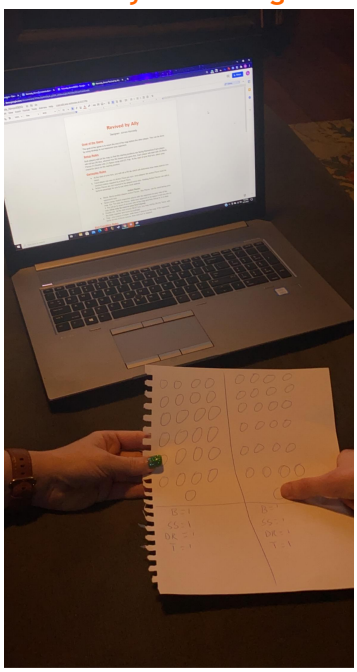
W3 Test #1 What went well -

After the first test, the game is playable and fun because it requires strategy to outplay your opponent. Both players understood the rules and nothing seemed to break the game while playing.

W3 Test #1 What needs to change -

The thing i would like to change is the values of the action pieces for more player choice and strategy. In my last test, i lowered the amount of times you can use them, but now it is too low and the game can get stale.

W3T1 Play Test Image



W3T1 Play test tracker

Revived by ally testing		Player 1	Player 2
1st test:			
	1st action piece	swap spaces	swap spaces
	2nd action piece	block	double roll
	3rd action piece	double roll	block
	4th action piece	trap	trap
	Block card used to negate:	swap spaces	double roll
	(what card did you negate)		
	Number of turns to win:	15	

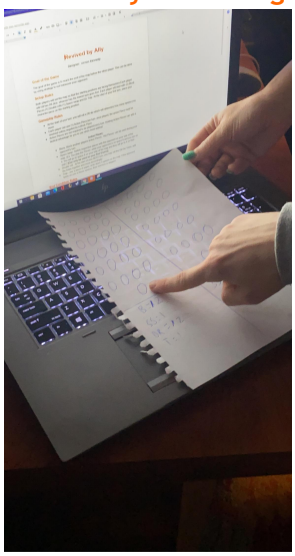
W3T1 Test #2 What went well -

In this test, I included a new first move mechanic and a different level of action pieces. This made the game more interesting because it allowed both players more player choice to complete the game. For right now, the changes did not feel overpowered in any way and gave players a chance to explore what the game has to offer.

W3T2 Test #2 What needs to change -

Something that needs to change is how many spaces there are! The game is over really quick which is okay because it is supposed to be short, but it feels like the game should be slightly longer to really utilize the action pieces in a way that feels like it's not rushed or forced!

W3T2 Play Test Image



W3T2 Play test tracker

2nd test:		player 1	player 2
	1st action piece	double roll	block
	2nd action piece	double roll	block
	3rd action piece	block	swap spaces
	4th action piece	swap spaces	double roll
	5th action piece	block	double roll
	6th action piece	block	trap
	1st Block piece used to negate:	double roll	double roll
	2nd Block piece used to negate:	trap	double roll
	(what card did you negate)		
	Number of turns to win:	17	

W3 Calculate probability

Probability rolls for deciding who goes first:	
2	1/36
3	2/36
4	3/36
5	4/36
6	5/36
7	6/36
8	5/36
9	4/36
10	3/36
11	2/36
12	1/36

Probability of moving:	
1	1/6
2	1/6
3	1/6
4	1/6
5	1/6
6	1/6

W3 Change List

You are required to make AT LEAST 3 major revisions to the game each week. They should be listed below

- Changed how the first move is selected
- Rebalanced action piece uses.
- Changed the “swap spaces” activation requirements to a turned based system instead of a space system.

Week 4

For this week, try and get all the final polish on your month long project. If you can, make the board look nice. Make sure all the directions are clear and free of grammatical errors. Do a final pass (I know, it's a lot of iteration, but that's what we do).

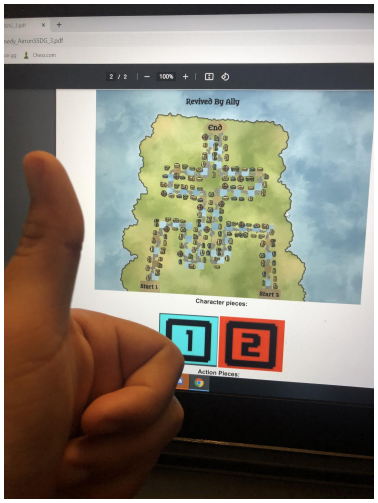
Week 4 Play tests

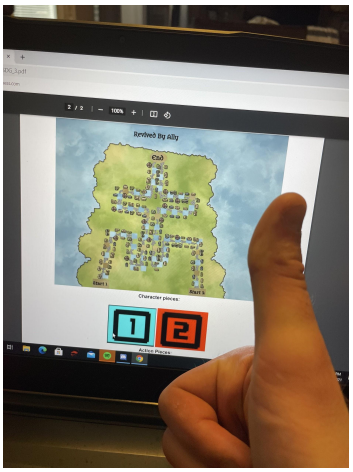
Final Play Test

For this test, I monitored 2 friends via the internet to test my game. Recording their data was more difficult because I had to watch and ask for every step of their gameplay. With the iterations from last week's changes, I was able to record data on the action pieces and found that the pieces that had been overused were now being used less which was intended. Using 2

dice rolls instead of one proved to make the game more fun because it added another way for human decision and allowed the players to strategize.

Play Test Image





Experiments

1) My first experiment, i wanted to test how the game plays if i was to remove a big player decision mechanic in my game. As hypothesized, the game was more just luck and hoping you'd roll a high number to pass up your opponent. This led to stale gameplay and led me to realize that this mechanic was important to have in the game regardless of how tedious it was to balance.

2) In this experiment, I doubled the amount of spaces there were but kept the same limitations on the action pieces, except for the trap piece which I doubled its value from 3 to 6. This caused the game to be much longer because action pieces couldnt be used more than once which then caused the end of the game to be boring because it was just rolling the dice multiple times. In the end, I concluded that if the game was longer, it would have to have more action cards respectively for it to work.

3) In my final experiment, I doubled the dice rolls and action pieces as well as the size of the map. My thought process in this is that in one of the lectures this week, it was talked about that people like bigger numbers so essentially, it is the same game but just bigger. This caused the game to be longer and require more actions because the players could use multiple new combos against their opponent. I really enjoyed this version of the game but it is clear that more balancing would need to be done to fully polish it.

Change List

You are required to make AT LEAST 3 major revisions to the game each week. They should be listed below. For this final week, your changes may be your experiments, or last changes needed to improve the game.

- Updated Trap Usage.
- Changed dice rolls to make the game more engaging
- Removed action pieces for an experiment

Final Thoughts

This month has taught me the importance of balancing a game. After multiple attempts of balance, particularly in the Action Piece design, they had to be balanced every single week just to find a good spot for them. This includes finding enough people who can test the game and try different strategies every week to further your knowledge on how your game works on a wide range of people.

Another thing i've learned this month is how important it is to correctly phrase rules so that someone who is playing can fully understand what is going on. I noticed in both playtests and games I played of other students that sometimes it is hard to understand what they are trying to say but then make 100% sense when they explain it to you. Unfortunately, when making a board game, you don't always have the opportunity to explain the inner workings of the game in person so your rules have to be very clear so people can enjoy it.

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